

Royal Arch Grand Bodies in America

The first meeting of delegates out of which arose the General Grand Chapter was at Boston, October 24, 1797. The Convention adjourned to assemble at Hartford, in January, 1798, and it was there the Grand Chapter of the Northern States of America was organized. Again, on the 9th of January, 1799, an adjourned meeting was held, whereat it was resolved to change its name to that of General Grand Royal Arch Chapter of the Northern States of America. On January 9, 1806, the present designation was adopted, to wit: "The General Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masonry for the United States of America." New York was determined upon as the place for the first Convocation, September, 1812, and the sessions to be made sentential, every seventh year. It failed to meet at the appointed time, but an important Convocation was held in New York City, on June 6, 1816.

Joseph K. Wheeler, Grand Secretary, in his introduction to the Records of Capitular Masonry in the State of Connecticut, says, after mentioning the names of the Chapters represented at the organization of the Grand Chapter in 1798: "In tracing their history it will be observed that all of these Chapters obtained their authority from a Washington Chapter in the city of New York, with the exception of Vanderbroeck, No. 5," chartered at an early date, by the Grand Chapter of New York, after which no more Chapters were established by any authority outside the Jurisdiction of Connecticut except Lynch Chapter, No. 8, located at Reading and Weston, which was chartered by the Grand Chapter of New York, August 23, 1801, which charter was signed by Francis Lynch, High Priest, Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons; James Woods, King; and Samuel Clark, Scribe; which was admitted to membership in Grand Chapter of Connecticut, May 19, 1808.

It is of interest here to note that the oldest Chapter in New York State is Ancient, No. 1, whose date of origin is lost, its records up to 1804 having been destroyed by fire, but tradition fixes the year 1763. For years it wielded the powers of a Grand Chapter, and until 1799 was known as the Old Grand Chapter. It granted Charters for Chapters in New York, New Jersey, and Connecticut. In this last named State it issued a Charter to Lynch Chapter (See above) which was received into full fellowship by the Grand Chapter of Connecticut although the Grand Chapter of New York had been in existence some time before the Charter was issued.

On the formation of the Grand Chapter of the State of New York, the numbers 1 and 2 were left vacant for the acceptance of Old and Washington Chapters, which latter was an offspring of the former, who at that time refused to place themselves under its Jurisdiction. In 1808, Old Chapter enrolled itself as Ancient under the State Grand Body, accepted the number one, and was further honored by having its High Priest, James Woods, elected Deputy Grand High Priest. The organization of the General Grand Chapter is explained at length in Doctor Mackey's revised History of Freemasonry.

PROCEEDINGS OF THE General Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons OF THE UNITED STATES .
1797 .

FIRST CONVENTION TO FORM A GRAND CHAPTER .

At a Convention of Committees from the following Chapters of Royal Arch Masons , viz : ST . ANDREW'S CHAPTER , Boston ; TEMPLE CHAPTER , Albany ; and NEWBURYPORT CHAPTER ; holden at Mason's Hall , Boston , Massachusetts , Wednesday , October 24th , 1797 :

PRESENT :

M .. E .. BENJAMIN HURD , Jr. , H ... P ..

E .. JOHN SOLEY , Jr. , WILLIAM WOART,

M .. E .. THOMAS S. WEBB ,

JOHN HANMER ,

E .. JONATHAN GAGE ,

K ... Secretary , H ... P .. Scribe ,

P ... K ..

E .. JOSHUA GREENLEAF , K ..

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of ST . ANDREW'S CHAPTER . of ST . ANDREW'S CHAPTER . of ST . ANDREW'S CHAPTER . of TEMPLE CHAPTER ,
Albany . of TEMPLE CHAPTER , Albany . of NEWBURYPORT CHAPTER . of NEWBURYPORT CHAPTER .

The Most Excellent THOMAS SMITH WEBB , was chosen Chairman , and WILLIAM WOART , Scribe .

The companions above named , being regular Royal Arch Masons , having produced the credentials of their appointment by the several Chapters affixed to their names , as committees from said Chapters , to meet with any or every Chapter of Royal Arch Masons within the States of New Hampshire , Massachusetts , Rhode Island , Connecticut , Vermont and New York , or with any committee duly appointed by any or all of said Chapters , and deliberate on the propriety and expediency of erecting a Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons , within the said States : upon motion being made and seconded ,

Resolved , unanimously , That the following Circular Letter be forwarded to each of the Chapters within the said States , and that Comps . BENJAMIN HURD , Jr. , of ST . Andrew's Chapter , Boston , THOMAS S. WEBB , of TEMPLE CHAP- TER , Albany , and JONATHAN GAGE , of NEWBURYPORT CHAPTER , be and they and either of them hereby are appointed a committee for the purpose of trans- mitting copies of these proceedings and receiving communications and answers from said Chapters .

Companions :

CIRCULAR .

From time immemorial , we find that Grand Lodges of Free and Accepted Masons have been established wherever Masonry has flourished , for the purpose of granting warrants for the erecting private Lodges , as well as for the establishment of certain general rules and regulations for the government of the same .

It is an opinion generally received , and we think well authenticated , that no Grand Lodge of Master Masons can claim or exercise authority over any Convention or Chapter of Royal Arch Masons ; nor can any Chapter , although of standing immemorial , exercise the authority of a Grand Chapter . We therefore think it highly expedient for the regular government of all Chapters within the said States , who exercise the rights and privileges of Royal Arch Masons , and to prevent irregularities in the propagation and use of those rights and privileges , that there should be a Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons established within those States . And whereas , this Convention has received official information from our companions at Philadelphia , that the several Chapters within their vicinity have recently assembled and established a Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons for their government ; in conformity to their example , we think it our duty to recommend to the several Chapters within the said States of New Hampshire , Massachusetts , Rhode Island , Connecticut , Vermont , and New York , to unite and form a Grand Chapter for the said States .

The local situation of the States before mentioned , the easy and frequent intercourse between their several principal towns and cities , as well as the similarity of habits , manners and customs , as citizens and as Masons ,

which prevail throughout the said States , induce us to believe that a union of all the Chapters therein in one Grand Chapter will have the most useful , lasting , and happy effect in the uniform distribution and propagation of the sublime degrees of Masonry . They therefore take liberty of recommending to the consideration of your Most Excellent Chapter , the propriety of appointing one or more dele- gate or delegates to represent your Chapter at a meeting of the several Chapters before mentioned , to be holden at the City of Hartford , in the State of Connecticut , on the fourth Wednesday of January next ensuing , investing them with full power and authority , in conjunction with the other delegates , to form and open a Grand Chapter of Royal Arch Masons , and to establish a Constitution for the government and regulation of all the Chapters that now are or may be hereafter erected within the said States .

SIGNED ,

BENJAMIN HURD , Jr. , JOHN SOLEY , Jr. , WILLIAM WOART ,

Committee of St. Andrew's Chapter , Boston .

JONATHAN GAGE ,

JOSHUA GREENLEAF , Jr. , Committee of Newburyport Chapter .

THOMAS S. WEBB ,

JOHN HANMER ,

Committee of Temple Chapter , Albany .

A true record of the doings of this Convention of Com- mittees , October 24th , 1797 .

(ATTEST ,)

WILLIAM WOART ,

Scribe to the Convention .